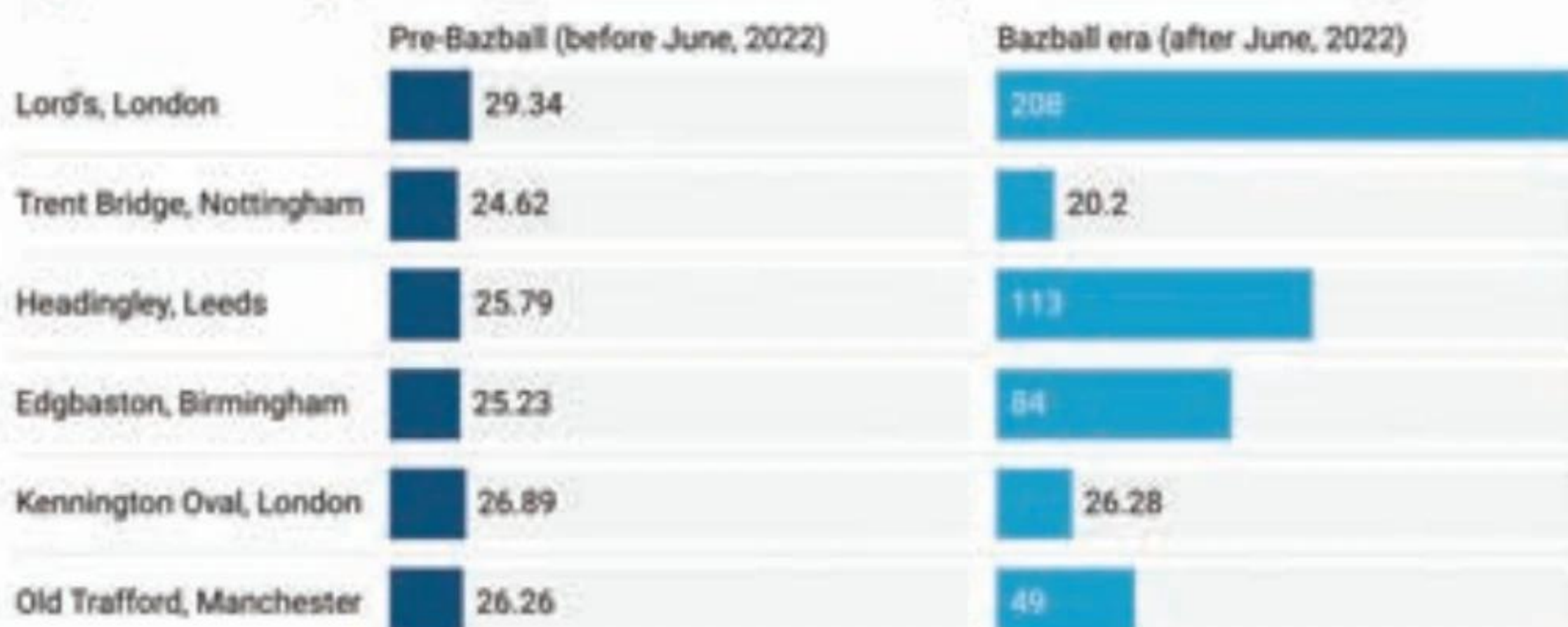


Spin bowling average in fourth innings of Tests in England



All six grounds to be used in Test cricket since June 2022.

Historically, chasing in the fourth innings was often considered futile due to pitch deterioration, which brought turn, bounce, and spin into play at crucial moments.

In Test cricket, spinners average worse than pacers in all four innings — but the gap narrows significantly in the final one.

Until 2022, spinners averaged 26.42 in fourth innings in England — the best figure outside India among nations to have hosted 100 Tests.

Since the advent of Bazball, however, that average has surged to 51.84 — the highest for any host country during this period.

At Headingley, for example, spinners averaged 25.59 in the

fourth innings prior to 2022. Since then, the figure has ballooned to over 113. Not surprisingly, three successful 200+ chases have come there in the Bazball era.

At Lord's, spinners have averaged an astonishing 208 in the fourth innings across seven Tests, with the side batting second winning five of them.

England's reluctance to chase in spin-friendly conditions is evident in its toss decisions abroad. In 2024, it played eight Tests in India and Pakistan. Of the four tosses it won, it chose to bat first in all of them.

Chasing a new era

England's chasing success — though helped significantly by

maximising home advantage — also reflects a broader trend in Test cricket: a growing frequency of successful fourth-innings hunts.

For much of Test cricket's early history, a successful 200-plus chase was a rare feat — just 14 such matches occurred until 1950.

Gradually, that began to change — particularly with the advent of covered pitches, which preserved the surface for longer and gave batters more of a chance in the final innings.

This shift peaked in the 2000s, when teams chased down 200+ totals on 33 occasions — aided by flatter pitches that took bowlers out of the game across much of the world.

The 2010s saw a partial rebalancing, with juicier tracks and more bowler-friendly conditions resulting in just 19 such chases.

The current decade, however, has seen a resurgence: 21 successful 200-plus chases so far, with England accounting for eight of them.

England's relentless charge with the bat on accommodating home pitches is unlikely to stop. The onus now lies with visiting teams: out-bat the host or out-think its batters to disrupt this dominance.

Successful 200+ run chases in Test cricket across decades

